

over the ruins of a coalition experiment. The reckless patriarch with his dynastic impulses is not

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portfolios like mining and urban development and a licence for the patriarch to be the power above the throne. Twice cheated, BJP opts for martyrdom.

The absence of political decency can't be starker. In his last desperate search for a partner—no matter whether it was Congress or BJP—Gowda was knocking on a few powerful doors in Delhi last week. His Janata Dal (Secular) was willing to sleep with the highest bidder, and the patriarch was running around soliciting. It was daylight political harlotry. In the end what Gowda wanted was not some kind of political stability or the restoration of the principle of power sharing but the pleasures of family power for a few more days. The pathology of it was matched only by its vulgarity. In the so-called age of coalition, regional satrapies like the Gowdas' bring home the unpleasant truth: you just can't co-habit with parties that are built to look after the interests of a few individuals. The profusion of regional parties—most of them have national aspirations—is not necessarily directly proportional to the federal evolution of India. It may reflect the expansiveness of Indian democracy and the near impossibility of bipolarity in politics. It nevertheless continues to be the primary source of political skulduggery and instability. In Karnataka, the size of the problem is as large as the greed and vanity of the Gowda clan.

It is not a unique Karnataka story, even if Gowda is singular in playing out his paternal instincts with such brazenness. The variations of the ugly Indian politician continue to be staged elsewhere as well, in equally gaudy backdrops. Next door, the world seen through the dark glasses of Dravidian exceptionalism is a very special place, where family values still dominate the script of power. For Karunanidhi, the Tamil interest comes only after the clan interest—one is negotiable, the other is not. In Kerala, Karunakaran, the doddering father-fighter, has already ceased to be even comical; he has become incomprehensible as power-lust is accompanied by senescence. In the

north we have all the types, ranging from the most accomplished performer of social justice to the avenging diva of dalit salvation. Lalu Prasad Yadav, currently one of the most trusted loyalists in the Sonia durbar, may play the subaltern jester for electoral effect. The legacy of the Lalu kitchen raj, though, is steeped in dynastic perversions of the badland variety. Mayawati has all the paranoia of the supreme leader who detests questions and invents enemies, and she too, like Lalu of the Bihar days, has turned the romance of social justice into a reign of terror and fear in the name of the dispossessed. They are only the most obvious ones, and they are united by the depravity of power. They carry forward the tradition of political pornography perfected by such veterans like Charan Singh, Raj Narain and Om Prakash Chautala.

The socialists, somehow, occupy the front row in the history of political vulgarism. Their evolutionary story is a study in how power repudiates the last vestige of idealism. The political heirs of Lohia have come a long way from lofty anti-Congressism; they have reduced the distance between pragmatism and opportunism with such unprincipled aplomb. They have become wreckers of the first order, though, today, they don't have a spiritual guru like Madhu Limaye. They have only performers with cultivated rusticity like Lalu Yadav. And the aesthetic of every political vulgarian is kitsch, which plays with the mass mind. The Nazis and Communists perfected it through the spectacles of the State. Today, almost every politician armed with a self-serving sociology of liberation is a practitioner of kitsch—from Jayalalithaa to Karunanidhi to Mayawati, all me-alone leaders driven by an exaggerated sense of indispensability. Kitsch in politics keeps the gullible mesmerised and gives the vulgarian in power a false sense of immortality.

Does it only further accentuate the farcical progression of the Indian project in democracy, which, after all, is elastic enough to accommodate any junk? In the first phase of freedom—the Nehruvian age—it was a project sustained by the idealism of nation-building, even though it was partly inspired by the Soviet model. Still, the romance was overwhelming for a generation of leaders shaped by the freedom movement. Politics remained largely honorable. The rise of Mrs G marked a defining cultural shift. The mythology of the great leader was born, and the durbar of the dynasty became the highest shrine of Indian democracy. Power began to rhyme with paranoia, and genealogy replaced ideology. As Gowda was frantically trying to restore family power in Bangalore, the first family of Indian politics was setting the stage for another dynastic ascension in Delhi amid such choreographed sycophancy. The Congress show presided over by the wannabe Mrs G looked so natural and inevitable while the farmer drew all the moral flak. So political pornography is not the prerogative of foxy farmers and kitschy vaudevillians alone; India's Grand Old Party has not abandoned the tradition. Maybe we mistake it for the sex appeal of Congress' future!

Gowda may take note: even in the enterprise of family politics, a good blend of experience and spin helps. It can make the ugly appealing. ■

Recognise him?
Our artist took
Gowda's face,
Lalu's ears,
Karunanidhi's
glasses and
Chautala's turban
to create this
familiar Indian
political entity.